My Sergei

By Ekaterina Gordeeva

EKATERINA: Not long ago I heard someone ask a friend, "If you had to live your life over again, what would you do differently?" I've thought about this, and for me, I'd like to live my life over again backward. Any day I'm living now, I would exchange for any day in the past because I know that for me to find the kind of happiness I had with Sergei isn't possible. It's like trying to find the comet that was in the night sky last spring, which passes Earth once in seventeen thousand years. No matter what lies ahead, the best years of my life will have been with my Seriozha, and those years are now laid to rest.

INTRODUCTION

In the former Soviet Union, the sports establishment, charged with producing winners for the greater glory of the empire, had almost unlimited power over the athletically gifted. Children as young as five or six were identified, sent to special schools and given rigorous training in the sports in which they were expected to excel. Two such youngsters were Ekaterina Gordeeva and Sergei Grinkov, paired as skaters by their teachers when they were 11 and 14. As time passed and their joint career led to international championships, they fell in love and married. Their success culminated in Olympic gold medals in 1990 and 1994. And then, suddenly, Grinkov died of a heart attack in 1995 at age 28. My Sergei by Ekaterina Gordeeva

EKATERINA: God took Sergei without warning – a heart attack on November 20, 1995. I lost my husband and best friend. I lost my favorite thing to do, because now I had no skating partner. It's like I was living in a fairy tale before, and now I've been abandoned in a wild forest.

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That is what life with Sergei was like, a fairy tale. It began the year I turned eleven. The pairs coach where I had skated since I was four, told me to come early to practice one day. He had chosen a skating partner for me. I was very excited because I knew it was going to be Sergei.

As a pairs skater, you have to learn everything you learned as a singles skater over again because you have to align your body with your partner's. Sergei and I practiced the jumps endlessly. I was never scared of the lifts because I always felt very safe in Sergei's arms. I'm not sure why, but once we were paired, I always believed Sergei was the only one who could skate with me.

Several years passed, we both grew up and we began preparing for the 1988 Olympics. As the games approached, everything became a little more stressful, a little more intense. In mid-November, during practice for an exhibition, Sergei caught his blade in a soft rut in the ice while holding me aloft and dropped me. The first part of my body to hit the ice was my forehead.

I didn't feel any pain at first, then my entire head felt like it was splitting apart. I blacked out and was driven to the hospital. I ended up staying for six days. I'd suffered quite a serious concussion. I was mad at Sergei because I thought this fall was his mistake. Then, there was a knock on the door, and it was Sergei.

He was carrying a dozen roses, and he was very, very upset. Sergei continued to visit me at home every dat. When at last I could skate again, I

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immediately noticed a change in the way he was holding me. Something had happened in those two weeks, and I realized that his thoughts for me had changed. Before we had been like two skaters. After that, we were a pair.

I wondered, why me? Why am I so lucky? I was so young and small and shy, and Sergei could have had any nice long-legged girl. Why should he choose me? I believed he would love me just for a little while, and then it would be over.

We went on to win the gold medal at the 1988 Olympics in Calgary, Canada. And the following year Sergei and I were married, and our daughter, Daria, was born a year and a half later. Then in 1994 we won our second Olympic gold medal. The first gold medal we had won for the Soviet Union. This one we won for each other.

In 1995, we were training in Lake Placid for a fifty-five-city tour with the Stars on Ice. At the beginning of the program, I'm on one knee, and Sergei is on one knee, and we are face-to-face. I put my head on his shoulder, and I remember that his T-shirt smelled very clean. So I said, "Humm, smells good." And he said, "Yes, it's clean" Just that. They were to be his last words.

Then we started to skate. We did the early movements – the camel spin into a lift. The full orchestra was just coming in. Sergei was gliding on the ice, but he didn't do the crossovers. His hand didn't go around my waist for the lift. I thought it was his back, which had been bothering him for some time. He was bent over slightly, and I asked him, "Is it your back?" He

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shook his head a little. He tried to stop, but he kept gliding into the boards. He was dizzy, but he didn't tell me what was happening. Then he bent his knees and ay down on the ice very carefully.

I kept asking what was happening. "What's wrong, Seriozha? What's the matter?" But he didn't tell me. He didn't speak at all.

Marina, our choreographer, stopped the music. When she came over to him, she knew right away it was something with his heart. It looked like he couldn't breathe anymore. She told me to all 911, and she started doing CPR on him. I was so scared. I was screaming. I don't know what. I forgot all the words in English. I couldn't remember the word for help. I ran, crying, to get someone to call 911 for me.

By the time I got back, everyone was around Sergei, and the medical people were working on him, trying to get his heart going. Then the medical people were taking him in the ambulance, and I only had time to get my skates off and pick up Sergei's bag. They had given him electric shocks. They had given him a shot of Adrenalin in the heart. But they had lost Sergei.

I can't describe the feelings that went through me when I walked into the room where Sergei was lying, still with his skates on. It looked like he was just sleeping. I talked to him, all the time thinking: He will ever stand up. He will never take me in his arms again, never hug me again, never hold my hand again.

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Then I started to take off his skates, and his feet were very cold. I tried to warm them up by rubbing them. I tried to warm his hands, too. I loved his hands very much – so big and soft. But I couldn't make them warm.

The next morning I sat Daria down and we talked. "Your father is dead; he's not coming back." Daria didn't cry or get upset. But she asked: "How can we see him?" So I told her that her father would come and see her whenever he wants and that sometimes she'd see him in her dreams. That he was like a little angel now. But that he'd never come back to her as we knew him and that it was very sad, and sometimes I would be crying, and that would be the reason.

We stayed in Moscow, living with my parents and taking one day at a time. I felt I was slowly losing myself. I had no purpose in my life, nothing to strive for. When I opened my eyes in the morning, I'd lie in bed wondering, Why do I awaken? I had nothing. No Sergei. Always the thoughts ended there. No Sergei to lead me out of the unending darkness.

I began to realize that work was what could help me heal. I still had skating. It was difficult for me to imagine myself skating in front of people without holding Sergei's hand, without looking into Sergei's eyes, looking only at the audience, trying to fill that huge ice surface all by myself. But if I was going to skate, that was how it would have to be. I wasn't going to skate with another partner. Sergei's was the only hand I had held on the ice since I was eleven years old.

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The tribute night arrived. I was waiting behind the curtain, not watching for fear that I would cry and lose my composure. When I heard the music of Moonlight Sonata, so many memories came back. I found myself going through my movements for our free program from the 1994 Olympics. Here Sergei throws me. Here we spin. . . . I couldn't stop myself. I didn't want to stop myself. I felt Sergei's spirit was beside me right then.

As the time neared for my solo number, a prayerful tribute to my union with Sergei, I thought about the words he used to say to me when we were getting ready to skate. We always kissed each other before we skated, we always hugged and touched each other. In the tunnel, waiting to go on the ice, I didn't have anyone to touch or kiss. It was a terrible feeling to be standing there by myself. . . . "Just trust Sergei. He will help you." The lights rose, the people started to applaud and I had a feeling I'd never experienced before. I'd been worried that I'd be lost out there by myself. That I'd be so small no one would see me. But I felt so much bigger than I am. I felt huge, suddenly, like I filled the entire arena.

I thought, I can't stop or I'll lose all this magic and power. I just listened to my legs. And I listened to Sergei. It was like I had double power. I never felt so much power in myself, so much energy. I'd start a movement, and someone would finish it for me. I didn't have a thing in my head. It was all in my heart, all in my soul.

I'll never be able to skate this number as well again. I don't want to skate it again. It was such a special thing, and I don't know if Sergei would help me a second time.

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Afterward, I was supposed to say something, but as soon as I was handed the microphone, I couldn't think of any words. Then I remembered what I wanted to say: "I don't have enough words, but I want to wish to all of you: Try to find happiness in every day. At least one, smile to each other every day. And say just one extra time that you love the person who lives with you. Just say, 'I love you'.

That is what Sergei taught me.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ekaterina Gordeeva
Book: Chicken Soup for the Couple's Soul
ISBN: 978-1558746466S
Publisher: HCI
Date (Month/Year): 1999

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier

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